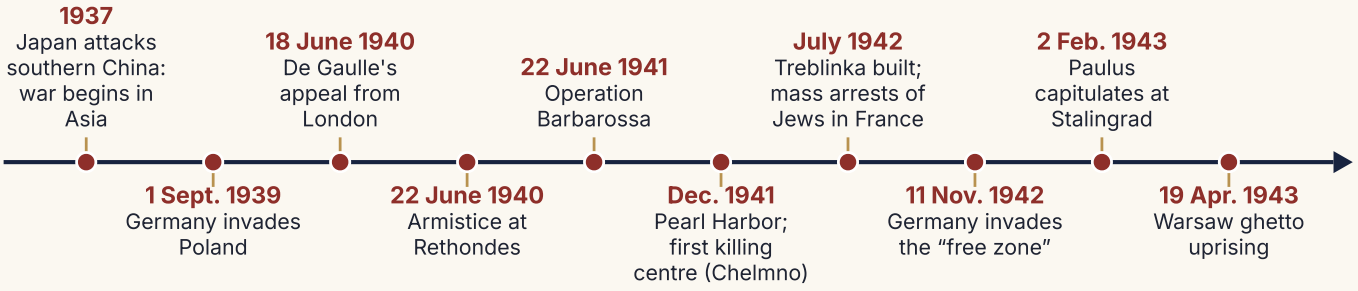
DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI

H3 World War Two

Theme 1 — The fragilisation of democracy, totalitarianism and WWII (1929–1945)

Objective. Assess the nature of the New European Order that Nazi Germany built through war, and the purposes it served — starting with the invasion and occupation of France.

Ten dates to know



The big picture

The Second World War was the ideological crucible of the twentieth century. It began before 1939 — in 1937 with Japan's attack on China, for historians such as Robert Frank — and ended with about 60 million dead. For the Nazis, conquest was the chance to build a New European Order: a continent organised by race, emptied of its Jews, colonised in the East, cleansed of communism, unified as one economic space and drained to supply Germany's total war. This chapter studies that order through three cases: the invasion of Western Europe, the quest for Lebensraum in the East, and the racial policy that led to genocide.

KEY ISSUES

- Assess the aims of the New European Order (WW2).

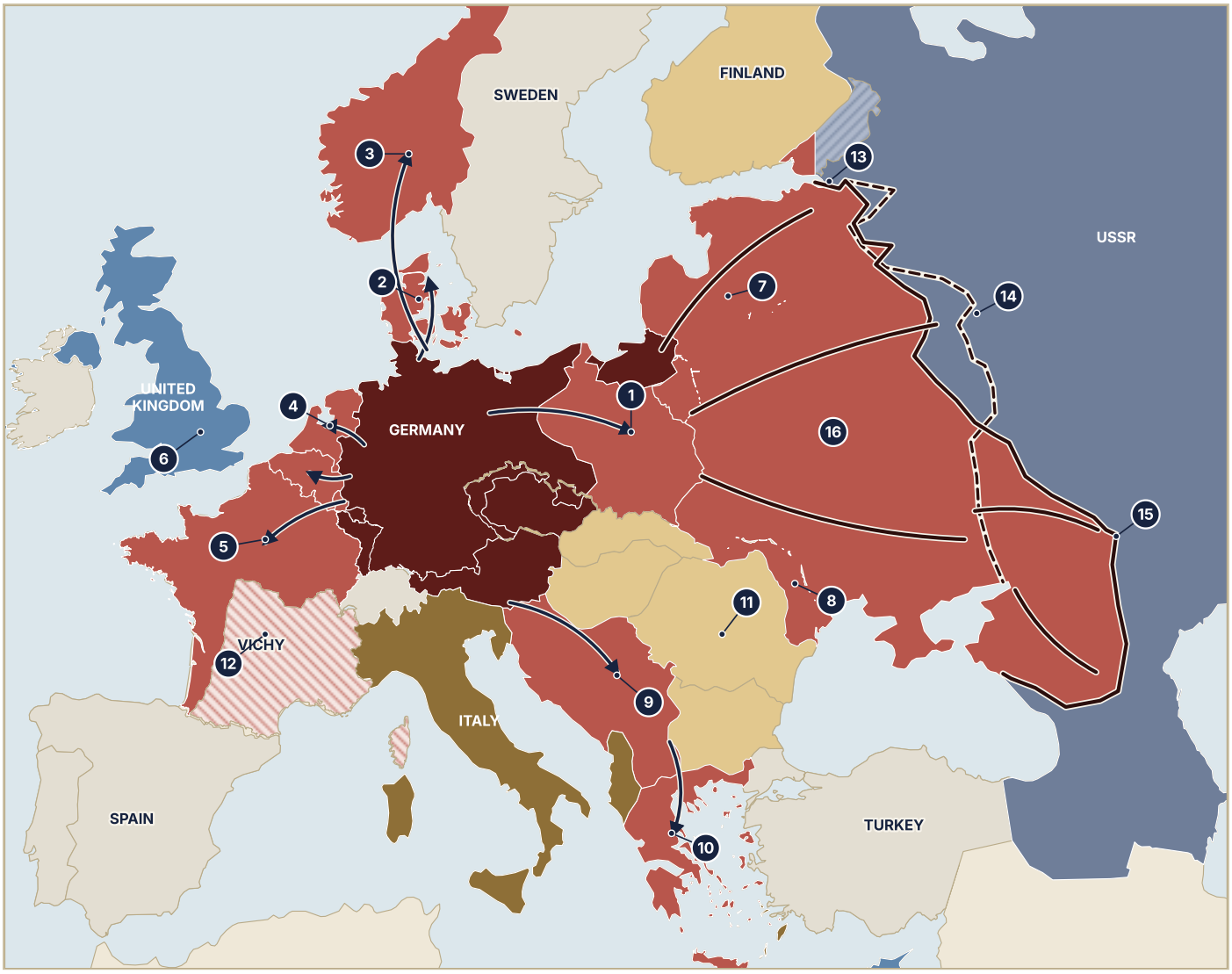
KEY TERMS

New European Order · Lebensraum

Summary diagram — The New European Order: the five driving forces announced in the introduction

1. Europe as a "racial entity": racial purification through genocide
2. The quest for Lebensraum in the East
3. A crusade against communism
4. The Grossraum: Europe as a single economic unit serving Germany
5. Supplying Germany with the people, materials and money required for total war

Summary map — Europe dominated by the Axis, and the war in the East (1939–1943)

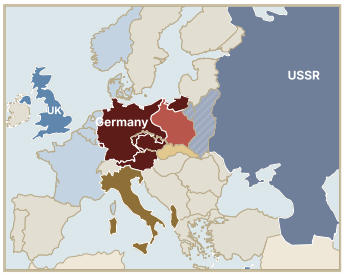


- The Reich: Germany, Austria, Sudetenland, Bohemia-Moravia, Alsace-Moselle (1940)
- Occupied by Germany and its allies (dates on the map)
- Vichy France, the “free zone” until 11 Nov. 1942
- Italy and Albania
- Allies of the Axis
- USSR (unoccupied)
- Soviet gains of 1939–40 still held in 1942
- United Kingdom: alone against Germany from June 1940 to June 1941
- Neutral states
- Front line, 5 Dec. 1941 (simplified)
- Front line, Nov. 1942: the furthest advance (simplified)

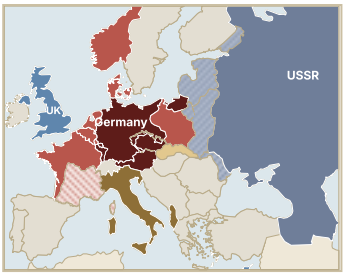
1. Poland, Sept. 1939: invaded, then partitioned with the USSR.
2. Denmark, Apr. 1940: occupied (outside the course).
3. Norway, Apr.–June 1940: invaded; Britain fails to prevent it, and Chamberlain falls.
4. Netherlands, Belgium, Luxembourg, from 10 May 1940: overrun in a few days.
5. France, May–June 1940: defeated in six weeks; armistice of 22 June.
6. United Kingdom: Churchill prime minister on 10 May 1940; the Blitz (1940–41) fails to win control of the air.
7. Baltic states, 1940: annexed by the USSR (course map), then overrun by Germany in 1941.
8. Bessarabia and Northern Bukovina, 1940: taken from Romania by the USSR (course map).
9. Yugoslavia, Apr. 1941: invaded and partitioned (outside the course).
10. Greece, Apr.–May 1941: occupied (outside the course).
11. Finland, Romania, Hungary, Slovakia: German allies against the USSR in 1941 (course map); Bulgaria joins the Axis in 1941 (outside the course).
12. Vichy: Pétain's regime, which chose collaboration.
13. Leningrad: besieged, never taken.
14. Moscow, Dec. 1941: the German advance stopped by the Red Army.
15. Stalingrad, Aug. 1942 – 2 Feb. 1943: the Germans stalled, encircled in November, Paulus capitulates: the turning point.
16. Occupied Soviet territory: scorched earth, war of annihilation, Soviet prisoners starved to death.

Dark arrows in the East: Operation Barbarossa (22 June 1941) and the summer offensive of 1942 towards Stalingrad and the Caucasus. Front lines and the Soviet border of 1941 simplified. Base: borders of 1930, with the changes of 1939–40 from the CShapes dataset.

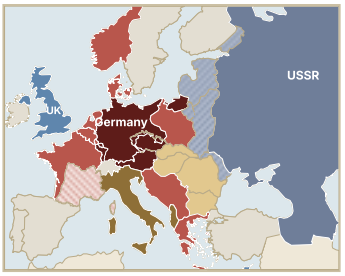
STAGE BY STAGE (SAME COLOURS)



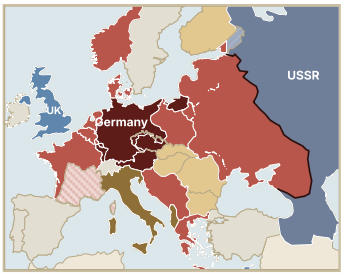
Oct. 1939 Poland conquered and partitioned with the USSR; the phoney war in the west.



July 1940 Denmark, Norway, the Benelux and France defeated; the USSR takes the Baltic states and Bessarabia; Britain alone.

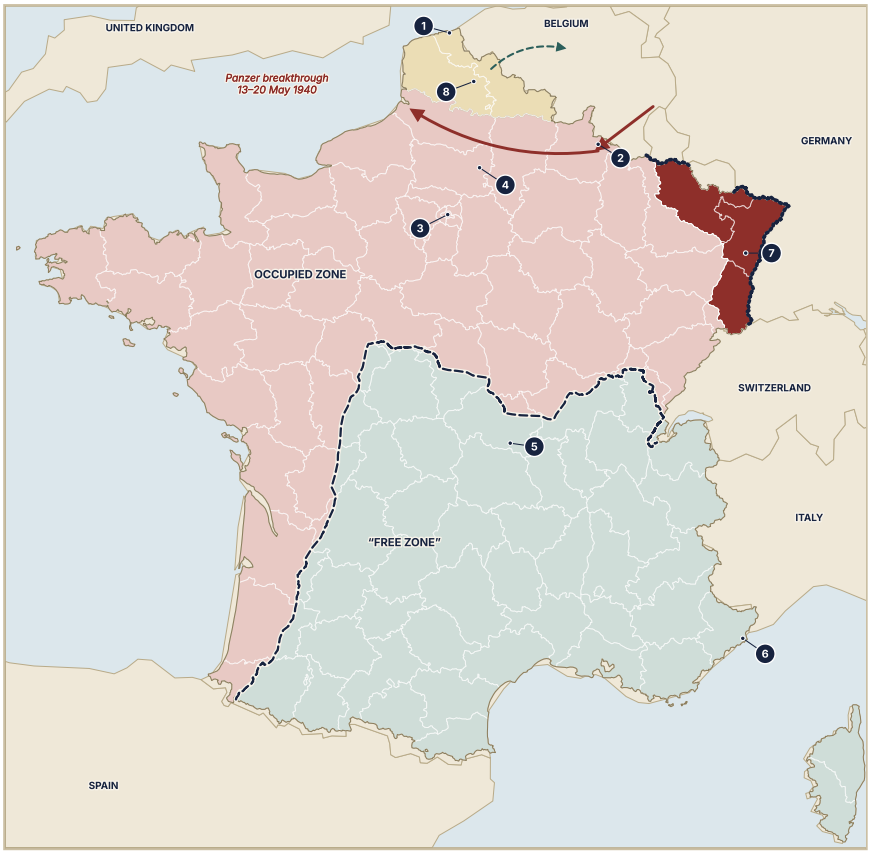


May 1941 The Balkans occupied; Hungary, Romania and Bulgaria in the Axis — on the eve of Barbarossa.



Nov. 1942 The furthest German advance: from besieged Leningrad to Stalingrad and the Caucasus.

Zoom — France defeated and cut up (1940–1942)



- Occupied zone: three-fifths of the country, German Military Command (MBF)
- "Free zone", governed from Vichy until 11 Nov. 1942
- Alsace-Moselle, annexed: back to the borders of 1871
- Nord and Pas-de-Calais, attached to the German command in Brussels
- Demarcation line
- Maginot Line (schematic): it did not cover the Belgian border

1. Dunkirk, 26 May–4 June 1940: Operation Dynamo, 338,000 soldiers evacuated.
2. Sedan, 13–20 May 1940: the armoured breakthrough after the Ardennes; Rommel's 7th Panzer Division races to the Somme.
3. Paris, 14 June 1940: German troops enter; some 8 million people on the roads of the exodus.
4. Rethondes, 22 June 1940: the armistice; 1,850,000 French prisoners.
5. Vichy: seat of Marshal Pétain's authoritarian regime, which chose collaboration.
6. Italian zone: about 15 communes in 1940, mainly in the Alpes-Maritimes; much larger from Nov. 1942 to Sept. 1943.
7. Alsace-Moselle: annexed and merged into German regions.
8. Nord and Pas-de-Calais: under the German Military Command in Brussels (MBB).

Red arrows: the German attack of May 1940; green dashes: the Allied advance into Belgium. Demarcation line: Département de l'Ain dataset (data.gouv.fr), drawn from the armistice documents.

Intro An ideological war, and the New European Order

The Second World War began before 1939

Many historians, including Jay Winter and Robert Frank, have shown that the war began before 1939, and its chronology can be stretched from 1931 to 1947. 1937 is the turning point: Japan attacked southern China, which immediately appealed to the League of Nations for help. The League proved incapable of regulating international tensions, which soon spread to a global scale.

EXAMPLE Robert Frank and Alya Aglan titled their book La Guerre-monde 1937–1947 (2015): the dates on the cover are an argument in themselves. Japan's invasion of southern China in 1937 is the event that opens it.

A war to destroy the enemy's civilisation, not only to defeat its armies

Unlike other wars, the Second World War was not only about defeating the enemy on the battlefield but about destroying their civilisation. It was an ideological war, in which no side would give up until death, and its toll was without precedent. It was, in the course's words, the ideological crucible of the twentieth century.

EXAMPLE The final death toll is about 60 million. The course opens the chapter with a photograph of Einsatzgruppen killers shooting men standing in a pit, around 1941–1942, probably taken by one of the killers.

The New European Order (key term): Nazi rule over Europe, presented as saving it

For the Nazis, war and conquest were the opportunity to build a grandiose political and economic apparatus that would entrench their domination of Europe. Its supporters presented this New European Order as saving European civilisation from collapse. The chapter assesses its nature and purposes through five driving forces: Europe as a "racial entity" and racial purification through genocide; the quest for Lebensraum in the East; the crusade against communism; the Grossraum, a single European economic unit; and the need to supply Germany with the people, materials and money required for total war.

EXAMPLE Hitler told the Reichstag on 11 December 1941 that this new order meant "the absolute elimination of the Jews, the establishment of the supremacy of the German people, and the creation of a real community of nations under German leadership".

I.1 Nazi invasion of Western Europe: the French case

1939–1941: the Axis overran continental Europe, and only Britain still resisted

Germany and the USSR were the two powers that attacked first, in 1939. By 1941 the Axis had made rapid progress: continental Europe was overcome, while the USSR had taken a share of eastern Europe. The only nation still resisting the Axis in 1941 was Britain. This is the situation the map of Europe 1939–1941 asks you to describe.

EXAMPLE German troops overran Belgium, the Netherlands, Luxembourg and France in six weeks from May 1940; after France's armistice in June 1940, Great Britain was the only country still fighting Nazi Germany.

France had a huge army, but an old-fashioned defensive strategy

France had one of the biggest armies in the world in 1940 — the largest in western Europe — but it was led by the victors of WWI and it was not very modern. France and Britain chose a defensive strategy: avoid a new trench war and its death toll, and withstand a massive German attack behind fortifications. From September 1939 to May 1940 little fighting took place in the west — the "phoney war".

EXAMPLE France had 105 divisions in 1940, more than Britain's 34. The Maginot Line, a sophisticated chain of fortifications along the border with Germany, did not cover the Franco-Belgian border.

The Blitzkrieg: the main attack came through the Ardennes, where nobody expected it

Germany sought a rapid victory through the Blitzkrieg, the "lightning war" of tanks and aircraft. British and French commanders believed the Germans would attack through central Belgium, as in 1914, and rushed their best forces there. The main attack instead went through the hilly Ardennes forest in south-eastern Belgium and northern Luxembourg; German tanks broke through the French lines and advanced to the Channel coast.

EXAMPLE The attack began on 10 May 1940, and the armoured breakthrough in the Ardennes came between 13 and 20 May. Erwin Rommel's 7th Panzer Division crossed the French countryside towards the Somme.

Dunkirk: the British saved their army, which the French lived as a betrayal

Trapped against the coast, the British Expeditionary Force organised a hasty evacuation by sea, Operation Dynamo. French troops saw it as a betrayal. But the evacuation left the Royal Navy and the RAF intact, and Churchill, newly appointed prime minister, insisted that Britain would fight on later with American aid.

EXAMPLE Between 26 May and 4 June 1940, Operation Dynamo lifted 338,000 Allied soldiers from the beaches of Dunkirk to Britain. Churchill had become prime minister on 10 May, the very day of the German attack.

Defeat in six weeks: Paris fell, millions fled, and France signed an armistice

German forces launched a major offensive from the Somme towards Paris, and the French government fled the capital. Paris fell six weeks after the campaign began. The human cost was huge, and millions of panic-stricken civilians took to the roads towards the south. France signed an armistice, leaving Britain alone against Germany.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Paris fell on 14 June 1940 and the armistice was signed on 22 June at Rethondes, in the Compiègne forest. About 100,000 French soldiers died in combat (recent research gives about 60,000 — added from outside the course), 200,000 were wounded and 1,850,000 were taken prisoner; some 8 million people joined the exodus.

France was cut into zones, each with a different master

Germany occupied three-fifths of mainland France — the areas with the highest economic potential and the Atlantic and northern coasts, to watch for any landing — under a German Military Command (MBF). A demarcation line separated it from the "free zone" governed from Vichy. Italy administered a small zone, the Nord and Pas-de-Calais were attached to the German command in Brussels, and Alsace and Moselle were annexed outright, restoring the borders of 1871.

> **EXAMPLE** About 15 communes, mainly in the Alpes-Maritimes, were administered by Italy. On 11 November 1942 German forces invaded the "free zone" in response to the Allied landing in French North Africa (Operation Torch).

Vichy: an authoritarian French state that chose to collaborate

The unoccupied zone came under a new government led by Marshal Pétain, established in the spa town of Vichy as an authoritarian regime. From the armistice onwards it sought collaboration with the German authorities. Although it was under Nazi pressure, it was often keen to collaborate, and it began persecuting Jews even before the Germans demanded it. General de Gaulle, who rejected the surrender, fled to Britain and launched Free France from London; its French National Committee (1941) then acted as a government in exile (added from outside the course).

> **EXAMPLE** In October 1940 a Vichy decree defined who was a Jew and limited their place in French society; in March 1941 Vichy created an Office for Jewish Affairs — French initiatives, not German orders.

France was exploited to feed the German war machine, in money, goods and workers

The occupation was above all an economic exploitation. France had to pay heavy occupation fees, which financed German requisitions and the plundering of French resources — coal, food, fuel — leading to rationing and a black market. From 1942 the Service du travail obligatoire (STO), created by Vichy, sent French workers to Germany as forced labour.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** France paid 20 million Reichsmarks a day in occupation fees. Under the labour law of September 1942 and the STO law of February 1943, all able-bodied men aged 18 to 50 and single women aged 21 to 35 could be sent. Before that, the Relève of June 1942 had promised to free one French prisoner of war for every three volunteer workers (Relève added from outside the course).

Jews were persecuted, dispossessed, then deported — by the occupier and by Vichy

In the occupied zone, Jews faced immediate persecution, comparable to that in Poland. Their businesses and property were confiscated under "Aryanisation" laws, leaving families without home or work. From June 1942 they had to wear the yellow star, and from the summer of 1942 they were arrested for deportation to the east — arrests carried out mainly by French police. From 1942, Jews were deported from the Vichy zone too.

> **EXAMPLE** About 350,000 Jews lived in France in 1940, more than half of them foreign refugees. Some 80,000 were deported during the war, and only about 3% of them survived. Note on the course: the lesson attributes the 1942 arrests to the Milice, but the Milice was only created in January 1943; the great round-up of July 1942 in Paris was the work of the French police.

Repression and seduction worked together: terror for opponents, flattery for the rest

Jews, communists and "terrorists" — the occupier's word for Resistance fighters — were targeted both by the Gestapo and by Vichy's police forces. At the same time the occupier tried to win the French over: German propaganda praised French culture, flattered French business and presented collaboration as the natural place of France in the new Europe.

> **EXAMPLE** The British weekly The Observer noted on 7 September 1941 that the German-run Pariser Zeitung presented Paris as the future holiday resort of the Nazi "Herrenvolk", and that "collaboration" was its daily theme — an attempt to win Paris "by flattery instead of by repression".

Conclusion on France: a special case that shows what the New European Order was for

France is a special case because decision-making was not unified: German occupation forces and French authorities coexisted. Repression and terror were used against opponents both by the Nazis and by Vichy; both implemented racist policies; and Germany used French territory and population to supply itself with the human, material and financial resources it needed for total war. That is the New European Order seen from one occupied country.

> **EXAMPLE** Three figures sum up the three dimensions: 20 million Reichsmarks a day (the money), the STO from 1942 (the workers), and some 80,000 Jews deported (the racial policy).

I.2 The British resistance supported by the US

In June 1940 the German command weighed two strategies against Britain: a direct attack, or a war on the periphery

Once France was defeated, Britain was the only enemy left in the west. Alfred Jodl, Chief of the Operations Staff of the German Armed Forces, set out the choice in a memorandum of June 1940: either "a direct attack on the English motherland", or "an extension of the war to peripheral areas" such as the Mediterranean and the trade routes. A direct strategy could take three forms: an offensive by air and sea against British shipping, combined with air attacks on centres of industry; terror attacks by air against population centres; and finally a landing to occupy England.

> **EXAMPLE** The Blitz put the second avenue into practice: the course slide shows a Luftwaffe bomber flying over the East End of London at the start of the evening raids of 7 September 1940.

The Blitz: bombing Britain into submission, at a heavy civilian cost

The Blitz was the German bombing campaign against the United Kingdom in 1940 and 1941. The Germans regarded the defeat of the Royal Air Force (RAF) as the condition for any invasion, so the air war came first: bombers struck docks, factories and, above all, cities, in order to break both British industry and the will of the population. Civilians were in the front line, as they had been in Spain and Poland.

> **EXAMPLE** The course gives 43,000 civilian dead in London. (This figure is usually given for the whole of the United Kingdom during the Blitz, about half of them in London: see "Points to watch".) The slide shows anti-aircraft guns set up in Hyde Park, in the heart of the capital.

Britain held because the Luftwaffe never won control of the air

The invasion depended on air superiority over south-eastern England, where a landing would take place. The German air force failed to win it in 1940. Hitler first postponed the invasion until the spring of 1941, then indefinitely, because Germany turned its forces against the Soviet Union. Britain was the first country to stop the Nazi war machine — not by defeating it, but by holding out.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** In December 1940 the first operational order for the invasion of the USSR was issued, and the invasion of Britain was postponed indefinitely. (The invasion plan was code-named Operation Sea Lion and the air battle of summer 1940 is known as the Battle of Britain: names added from outside the course.)

Two men refused defeat in June 1940: Churchill and de Gaulle

Churchill was already a major figure of the Conservative party and had opposed appeasement. When Britain failed to prevent the German occupation of Norway during the phoney war, and German forces invaded Belgium, Chamberlain lost the support of the House of Commons and resigned; Churchill became prime minister on 10 May 1940, the day German troops crossed the French border. De Gaulle had just been promoted general and appointed to Paul Reynaud's government. When Reynaud resigned and Marshal Pétain, a hero of the First World War, became head of the government pledging to sign an armistice, de Gaulle refused, fled France on 17 June to escape arrest, and met Churchill in London.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 2, Document A: in the Appeal of 18 June 1940, broadcast from London, de Gaulle declares that "the flame of French resistance must not and shall not die". Document B: on 4 June 1940, before the House of Commons, Churchill promises "we shall fight on the beaches [...] we shall never surrender".

Both men bet on a world war: the empires, the seas and the industry of the United States

Compared side by side, the two speeches share an analysis: the battle of France does not decide the war. Both count on empires that remain intact, on the British fleet that commands the seas, and on the industrial resources of the United States. The differences are just as clear. Churchill speaks as head of government, before the armistice, with Parliament and the nation behind him, to prepare Britain to fight alone. De Gaulle is an almost unknown general in exile, speaking after his own government has asked for an armistice, and he calls on individuals — officers, soldiers, engineers, workers — to join him.

> **EXAMPLE** De Gaulle: "This is a world war [...] Like England, she can draw unreservedly on the immense industrial resources of the United States." Churchill: "our Empire beyond the seas [...] would carry on the struggle, until, in God's good time, the New World, with all its power and might, steps forth to the rescue and the liberation of the old."

Before entering the war, the United States became Britain's supplier

The heading of the lesson insists on American support. Neutral by law since the Neutrality Acts, the United States moved step by step towards Britain: in November 1939 the "cash and carry" Neutrality Act let the democracies buy weapons if they paid in cash and carried them on their own ships (chapter 1). Roosevelt then presented the country, in December 1940, as the "Arsenal of Democracy". Britain could hold out because American factories worked for it long before American soldiers fought.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The Lend-Lease Act of March 1941 allowed the United States to lend or lease war materials to Britain without immediate payment — the end of cash and carry. (Example added from outside the course.)

December 1941: the war goes global

After conquering France, German troops turned east against the Soviet Union in June 1941, until they were abruptly stopped before Moscow in December 1941 (part II). The same month, on 7 December 1941, Japan, one of the Axis powers, bombed the American base of Pearl Harbor in Hawaii. The United States immediately declared war on Japan, and on 11 December Germany and Italy declared war on the United States. From then on the war was fought on every ocean and every continent, and Britain was no longer alone.

> **EXAMPLE** The front page of The Erie Daily Times of 11 December 1941, on the course slide: "U.S. Declares War on Germany, Italy" — "America Lines Up With Britain, Soviet Against Axis In World Struggle".

II.1 German plans for Eastern Europe

The Nazi-Soviet pact opened the road to the East

By the pact of August 1939 Hitler secured the neutrality of the Soviet Union, and in secret the two powers planned to carve up Poland. Germany felt ready to conquer its Lebensraum, the living space in the East announced in Mein Kampf. On 1 September 1939 Hitler invaded Poland; Britain and France declared war on 3 September. Within a month Poland was defeated and partitioned between Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union, which occupied eastern Poland on 17 September 1939.

> **EXAMPLE** The course slide shows Stalin and Ribbentrop shaking hands after the signing of the pact, and two maps: the German invasion routes of 1 September 1939, and Eastern Europe after the pact, with the German-Soviet demarcation line running between Warsaw and Białystok and between Lublin and Lvov. The second map also shows the Soviet annexations of 1940: Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania, and Northern Bukovina and Bessarabia, taken from Romania.

Why invade the USSR? An economic reason: the Grossraum and its resources

Hitler wanted a Grossraum, a "greater space": a larger and self-sufficient Third Reich. German settlements in the East and the enslavement of the Slavic populations were part of a plan of "Germanisation" of the East. The seizure of the natural resources of the USSR — farmland, minerals, oil — was an economic necessity to achieve autarky and to fight a long war.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 3: Stalingrad mattered because it was a major industrial and transport hub on the Volga that ensured Soviet access to the oil of the Caucasus — oil that the German war economy needed.

An ideological reason: the crusade against "Jewish Bolshevism"

Two populations were deemed "hostile" and "dangerous" to German rule in the East: the communist leaders and the Jews. Nazi rhetoric called the USSR a "Jewish Bolshevik" regime, merging the political enemy and the racial enemy into one. The Nazis sought the permanent elimination of this supposed threat. The war in the East was therefore not only a conquest but a war against a worldview.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Worksheet 3, Source 1: an order signed by General Alfred Jodl in May 1941 tells the troops that the political commissars (communist leaders) are the "originators of barbaric, Asiatic methods of warfare" and must, when captured, be "dispatched by firearms" as a matter of routine. The final "Commissar Order" was issued by the High Command of the Armed Forces on 6 June 1941 (added from outside the course).

A racial reason: the "Übermensch" against the "Untermensch"

The Nazis were convinced that they belonged to the Aryan "Übermensch", the "superior man", superior to the Slavic "Untermensch", the "inferior man". The Slavs were to be enslaved or driven out to make room for German settlers, and the Jews were to be eliminated. This racial hierarchy, already studied in chapter 2, turned the Eastern campaign into a war of destruction from the start.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 3, Source 2: the Severity Order of Field Marshal Walther von Reichenau, 10 October 1941, calls for "the extermination of the Asiatic influence in European civilisation" and for "severe but just retribution" against "the subhuman species of Jewry".

II.2 Operation Barbarossa: a war of annihilation (case study #2)

Operation Barbarossa (22 June 1941): a crusade that stalled before Moscow

Hitler broke the Molotov-Ribbentrop pact and launched the invasion of the USSR, code-named Operation Barbarossa, on 22 June 1941. The Wehrmacht regarded the war in the East as a crusade against communism. Until December 1941 German troops advanced deep into the Soviet Union, but stiffening Red Army resistance prevented them from capturing the key cities of Leningrad and Moscow. The Blitzkrieg that had won in six weeks in France failed in the immensity of Russia.

> **EXAMPLE** The course's death toll of Barbarossa: 200 days of warfare and 5 million deaths — on average a thousand people, mostly civilians, killed every hour.

Three thrusts across an immense front, with Germany's allies

The invasion was launched on a front running from the Baltic to the Black Sea. The course map shows three German thrusts: in the north through the Baltic states towards Leningrad, in the centre through Minsk and Smolensk towards Moscow, in the south through Ukraine and Kiev towards Rostov. Germany did not fight alone: the map labels Finland, Romania, Hungary, Slovakia, Italy and Croatia as German allies. In 1941 the advance stopped before Leningrad and Moscow; the push towards Stalingrad and the Caucasus came with a second offensive, in the summer of 1942.

> **EXAMPLE** The course map "Invasion of the Soviet Union 1941–1942": the yellow line of the "farthest German army advance" runs just west of Moscow and reaches Stalingrad on the Volga, while arrows from Rostov point to the Caucasus Mountains. A second map, "Operation Barbarossa", marks Leningrad, Moscow and Stalingrad with stars as the three objectives.

On the Soviet side: an army weakened by the purges, and scorched earth

The Red Army was disorganised and "beheaded" by the Great Purges, which had destroyed much of its officer corps. It retreated, but the population left nothing behind: Russian peasants fled ahead of the German troops, burning their harvested crops, driving their cattle away and destroying the buildings of their villages — the scorched-earth policy. The Red Army retreated, but it did not collapse: its resistance stopped the Germans before Leningrad and Moscow.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The purge struck the very top of the army: Marshal Mikhail Tukhachevsky, its leading strategist, was shot in June 1937 together with other senior commanders, and thousands of officers were dismissed or arrested (added from outside the course).

Stalin's answer (6 November 1941): annihilation for annihilation

Speaking in Moscow on 6 November 1941, on the eve of the anniversary of the revolution, while the German troops were still advancing on the capital, Stalin took up the Nazis' own word — Vernichtungskrieg, war of annihilation — and turned it against them. The task of all the peoples of the Soviet Union, of the fighters, the commanders and the political officials, was now to destroy the invaders "to the last man". On both sides the war in the East was declared a war without mercy: this is why it is called a war of annihilation.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The speech quoted on the course slide: "Well, if the Germans want a war of annihilation, they will get it. [...] to destroy all invading Germans occupying the territory of our homeland to the last man. No mercy to the German occupiers!" In the transcript given in the lesson notes, the first sentence is followed by "(stormy, prolonged applause)". The slide dates the speech 7 November: it was given on 6 November, in the Mayakovskaya metro station; on the 7th Stalin spoke at the Red Square parade. (Corrected from outside the course.)

A war of annihilation: on the Eastern Front, the rules of war disappeared

The violence of the Eastern Front was unprecedented in history. There was no longer any rule of war: the sole aim was the total destruction of the enemy, or resistance until death. War crimes became the normal course of the war — the murder or ill-treatment of civilians and prisoners, and violence without any clear military objective. Three fifths of all the dead of the Second World War died on the Eastern Front.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** About 2.8 million Soviet prisoners of war were killed by the German armed forces and special units between June 1941 and February 1942, mainly through starvation. In all, about 3.3 million of the 5.7 million Soviet prisoners died in German captivity — nearly six in ten (the course's "three survivors in 100" is not supported by the figures). (Corrected from outside the course.) Worksheet 3, Source 8: the Auschwitz-Birkenau camp was first built for Soviet prisoners, and gassing was applied first to them, then to the Jews.

Stalingrad (1942–1943): the turning point of the war

Leningrad, Moscow and Stalingrad were the strongholds of the Soviet defence. In the summer of 1942 the Germans, euphoric, drove towards the Volga and the Caucasus. The Russians defended Stalingrad at all costs: it was a stronghold of Stalin's defensive strategy, a major industrial and transport hub on the Volga that ensured Soviet access to Caucasus oil — strategic for the future of the conflict and for the German supply of oil — and a symbol, the city bearing Stalin's name. The German army was stalled, encircled in November 1942, and surrendered between 31 January and 2 February 1943: a resounding defeat for the Wehrmacht.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Stalin's Order No. 227, 28 July 1942: "It is time to finish retreating. Not one step back!" On 31 January 1943 Paulus, commander of the German army, surrendered; the last troops in the city gave up on 2 February. About 91,000 German soldiers were taken prisoner (Worksheet 3, Source 6, says 95,000). (Corrected from outside the course.)

By November 1942 the balance of forces had turned in favour of the Soviets

The course table of the forces facing each other at Stalingrad in November 1942 shows that the Germans no longer had the upper hand: the Red Army lined up more men (1,143,500 against 1,011,500), more artillery guns (13,541 against 10,290) and more tanks (894 against 675); only in aircraft were the Germans slightly ahead (1,216 against 1,115). Despite its enormous losses of 1941, the Soviet Union was mobilising faster than Germany. The divisions table of the introduction shows the same trend for the whole war: 200 Soviet divisions in 1940, 350 in 1943, 488 in 1945, while Germany peaked at 347 in 1944.

> **EXAMPLE** The two tables of the course read together: at Stalingrad in November 1942, about 132,000 more Soviet soldiers than German ones, and 3,251 more guns; across the war, the USSR alone fielded more divisions in 1944 than the whole Axis (400 against 349, Japan excluded). The German army was encircled in that same month of November 1942.

Stalingrad fits the definition of total war

Total war means the mobilisation of all of a society's resources and the blurring of the line between front and rear (Première recap H10). Stalingrad meets every criterion: the whole economy behind the front, with Soviet factories in the rear sending ever more aircraft, tanks and guns; fighting street by street and factory by factory, with civilians inside the battlefield; propaganda on both sides; and the refusal of any surrender until death or capture. The Soviet Union paid the highest price of the whole war: official estimates of Soviet losses are now 27 to 28 million, one in seven of the pre-war population.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 3, Source 7: at Stalingrad the USSR lost 1.13 million soldiers and civilians (killed, wounded or captured, including 500,000 killed) and the Germans and their allies 760,000; the Soviets lost 4,341 tanks and 2,769 aircraft. Source 6: German soldiers fought for the "Barricade factory" for weeks, and by 26 December 1942 "the horses have already been eaten".

III.1 The Jews stranded and persecuted

In 1933, more than two thirds of Europe's 9.5 million Jews lived in Eastern Europe

The course map "European Jewish population distribution circa 1933" counts about 9.5 million Jews in Europe. Most of them lived in the East: 6,760,000 in Eastern Europe, 1,644,200 in Central Europe, 766,600 in Northern and Western Europe and 329,200 in Southern Europe. The largest communities were in Poland (3 million) and the Soviet Union (2,525,000); Germany, where Nazi persecution began in 1933, had only 565,000. The conquest of Poland in 1939 and the invasion of the USSR in 1941 therefore brought the heart of European Jewry under Nazi rule: the Jews were stranded, trapped in a continent that Germany and its allies controlled almost entirely by 1942.

> **EXAMPLE** The course map "German administration of Europe 1942" shows the trap: Greater Germany and the occupied territories stretched from France to Ukraine (General Government, Reichskommissariat Ostland and Ukraine), surrounded by allied or dependent states (Hungary, Romania, Slovakia, Croatia, Vichy France). Only Britain and a few neutral states (Spain, Switzerland, Sweden) remained outside.

From 1939, the Jews of Poland were locked into ghettos

In occupied Poland, the Germans concentrated the Jews in ghettos: closed districts of the cities, cut off from the rest of the population, into which they were forced to move with almost nothing. The course map "Ghettos in occupied Poland 1939–1941" places them mainly in the General Government, the part of Poland run by a German civil administration, and along its western edge: Warsaw, Lodz, Krakow, Lublin, Radom, Kielce, Czestochowa. After the invasion of the USSR the system spread east: the map "Ghettos in occupied Eastern Europe 1941–1942" shows ghettos from Riga and Vilna to Minsk, Lvov, Kishinev and Odessa. The ghetto was not yet extermination, but it isolated, impoverished and weakened the Jews, and gathered them in places from which they could later be deported.

> **EXAMPLE** Warsaw, Lodz and Krakow on the course map of 1939–1941; Kovno, Vilna, Minsk, Lvov and Odessa on the map of 1941–1942. Avraham Bomba, whose testimony is in Worksheet 4, was deported from the Czestochowa ghetto to Treblinka on 25 September 1942.

The Warsaw ghetto: 440,000 Jews locked up in 4 km²

Warsaw had the largest ghetto: 440,000 Jews locked up in about 4 km². Forced to leave their homes to join the ghetto, they could take only the bare minimum and were dispossessed overnight of their last belongings. The ghetto was surrounded by a wall 3 metres high and 18 km long; reduced in 1941, the closed area reached a density of 146,000 inhabitants per km². Chłodna Street, with its trams and cars, stayed outside the ghetto and cut it in two: a wooden footbridge built over it connected the small ghetto and the large ghetto.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** 146,000 inhabitants per km² in 1941, according to the course: about seven times the density of Paris today, some 20,000 per km² (comparison added from outside the course, INSEE). The photo of the Chłodna Street footbridge shows the crowd crossing above the street.

In the ghetto, death became part of daily life

Hunger, cold, overcrowding and disease killed on a massive scale. Food had to be smuggled in, often by children, at the risk of arrest. The corpses were picked up daily, usually at night, in the streets of the ghetto by members of the Jewish death care service; some were buried in the Jewish cemetery inside the ghetto, others thrown into mass graves, especially in the sports ground next to the cemetery. Death was so much part of daily life that the population ended up no longer paying attention to the corpses lying in the streets.

> **EXAMPLE** In 1942, the Warsaw ghetto averaged 1 birth for every 45 deaths (course). A photo of the course shows a group of children arrested in the ghetto for food smuggling (1940–1943).

19 April–16 May 1943: the Warsaw ghetto uprising

In April 1943, German troops and police entered the ghetto to deport its surviving inhabitants (most of the others had already been deported to Treblinka in 1942, see III.3). The Jews rose up: the Warsaw ghetto uprising lasted from 19 April to 16 May 1943. The Germans crushed it by destroying the ghetto house by house. On 16 May, the SS commander Jürgen Stroop sent Himmler a message announcing the result: "The Jewish Quarter of Warsaw is No More!"

> **EXAMPLE** Stroop's report, titled in German "Es gibt keinen jüdischen Wohnbezirk in Warschau mehr!": its cover, shown in the course, bears the stamp of the International Military Tribunal, because the perpetrator's own report was used as evidence against the Nazi leaders at Nuremberg.

Raul Hilberg: destruction, the last of three stages of anti-Jewish policy

In Claude Lanzmann's film Shoah (1985), the historian Raul Hilberg, author of The Destruction of the European Jews (1961), places Nazi policy in a long history of persecution. He distinguishes three stages. First conversion: the Christian missionaries told the Jews, in effect, that they had no right to live among them as Jews. Then expulsion: the secular rulers who followed told them that they had no right to live among them. Finally destruction: the Nazis decreed that they had no right to live. Before the twentieth century, the Church and Christian states had already invented most of the measures the Nazis reused — the distinctive badge, the ghetto, the ban on mixed marriages. The Nazis' only "invention" was the last step: the systematic killing of all the Jews, the "Final Solution".

> **EXAMPLE** Hilberg's table sets canon law against Nazi measures: the badge imposed by the Fourth Lateran Council (1215) and the Jewish star decreed on 1 September 1941; the compulsory ghettos of the Synod of Breslau (1267) and Heydrich's order of 21 September 1939 (dates added from Hilberg's book, outside the slides). The three questions of the course and the site's answers are in the panel below.

III.2 Role of the Einsatzgruppen (killing mobile squads)

Behind the Wehrmacht, mobile killing squads: the first step of the "Final Solution"

When Germany invaded the USSR on 22 June 1941, four Einsatzgruppen — A, B, C and D — followed the army. They were mobile killing squads of the SS and the police (Security Police and SD), about 3,000 men in all (composition and number added from outside the course, US Holocaust Memorial Museum). The course map "The genocide of the Jews of Europe" shows their progression: group A through the Baltic states, B towards Belarus and Moscow, C into Ukraine, D into southern Ukraine and the Crimea. The course calls their work "the first step of the Final Solution": the war of annihilation against the USSR (II.2) was also, from its first days, a war against the Jews.

> **EXAMPLE** On the course map, Einsatzgruppe A crosses the Baltic states, where the Jewish communities were almost wiped out: in Lithuania, 140,000 Jews killed out of 145,000 (97%); in Latvia, 70,000 out of 95,000 (75%).

Their targets: Jews above all, killed by mass shooting

The Einsatzgruppen were ordered to kill the "enemies" of the Reich behind the front: Jews above all, but also communist officials and Roma. At first they shot mostly Jewish men; from August 1941 they killed whole communities, women and children included (added from outside the course, US Holocaust Memorial Museum). The method was mass shooting: the victims were led out of town and shot at the edge of pits or ravines. This is why historians speak of the "Shoah by bullets" (Shoah par balles), the expression used on the course map.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The course shows the photo whose German inscription reads "Ukraine 1942, Jewish Action, Ivangorod": a soldier aims his rifle at a woman holding a child. It was mailed from the Eastern Front to Germany and intercepted at a Warsaw post office by a member of the Polish resistance. Outside the course: at Babi Yar, near Kiev, 33,771 Jews were shot in two days, on 29–30 September 1941 (US Holocaust Memorial Museum).

Helped by the army, the police and local auxiliaries, they killed more than a million Jews

The Einsatzgruppen were few, but they did not act alone: battalions of the Order Police, units of the Wehrmacht and local auxiliaries recruited in the occupied territories (Lithuanians, Latvians, Ukrainians) helped them round up, guard and shoot the victims. By the spring of 1943, the Einsatzgruppen had killed more than a million Soviet Jews (helpers and figure added from outside the course, US Holocaust Memorial Museum). The German footage of a shooting at Liepaja, in Latvia, in 1941, shown in the course, proves that these killings were seen, and even filmed, by German soldiers.

> **EXAMPLE** On the course map, 1,000,000 of the 3,020,000 Jews of the USSR were killed — a third (the map prints 23%, a misprint: 1,000,000 out of 3,020,000 is 33%): almost all of them by shooting, since the killing centres were in Poland.

III.3 Killing centres (case study #3: Treblinka)

Six killing centres, all in occupied Poland, from December 1941

From December 1941, the Nazis operated six killing centres — "sophisticated centres of mass murder", in the words of the course — all in occupied Poland: Chelmno, in the part annexed to Greater Germany; Treblinka, Sobibor, Belzec and Majdanek in the General Government; Auschwitz, at the edge of Greater Germany. Unlike concentration camps, which imprisoned and exploited their inmates, they existed to kill. They lay in Poland, at the heart of the largest Jewish community in Europe, close to the ghettos and on the railway network.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The course map "Extermination camps in occupied Poland 1942". The first centre, Chelmno, began gassing on 8 December 1941 (date added from outside the course, US Holocaust Memorial Museum); Treblinka was built in July 1942 (Worksheet 4).

Gassed upon arrival: murder organised like an industry

In the killing centres, the Jews were gassed upon arrival — first the men, then the women and children — except a small group of slaves kept alive to work in the camp and to dispose of the bodies (the Sonderkommando). The corpses were burned, in the open air or, at Auschwitz, in ovens. The killing was organised like an industry: at Treblinka, in October 1942, the capacity of the gas chambers was raised to 3,000 Jews per hour, and each train brought 6,000 to 7,000 people.

> **EXAMPLE** Avraham Bomba's testimony (1990, Worksheet 4): a concrete gas chamber of about 6 m × 6 m, with no windows, with pipes that made it look as if water would come out, filled as tightly as possible, children thrown on top; "the whole thing took I would say between 5–7 minutes".

Auschwitz and Majdanek: Zyklon B and selections for slave labour

Auschwitz and Majdanek were different: they combined a killing centre with a concentration and labour camp. A new gas was used there, Zyklon B, and the Nazis organised selections on arrival: the healthy became slaves for the German war effort, while the others — about 80% — were immediately driven to the gas chambers. Auschwitz-Birkenau had first been built for Soviet prisoners of war, who were the first to be gassed there (Worksheet 3, II.2).

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Note on the dates: the slide places the selections "after 1944"; in fact they began at Auschwitz in 1942, and 1944 was their peak, with the deportation of the Jews of Hungary (added from outside the course, US Holocaust Memorial Museum). On the course map, Hungary lost 550,000 of its 725,000 Jews (76%).

Case study #3: Treblinka, July 1942 – October 1943

Treblinka was built in July 1942 in the General Government, north-east of Warsaw (about 80 km away, added from outside the course). Until it closed in October 1943, it killed 876,000 people: 874,000 Jews, most of them from the Warsaw ghetto and other ghettos, and 2,000 Roma. The victims arrived by train, in freight cars, deported under guard. Everything was designed to deceive them until the last moment: a notice announced that after bathing and changing their clothes, the Jews would continue their journey to the east, to work. On 2 August 1943, 700 slave Jews launched an uprising and set the camp on fire; of those who broke through, about 70 are known to have survived until the end of the war.

> **EXAMPLE** Avraham Lindwasser arrived from Warsaw on 28 August 1942 and testified at the Eichmann trial in 1961: at the ramp, the order "Get out", shouts and blows, money and jewellery handed over, shoes removed, rows of three. Kept alive as a slave for a year, he escaped during the revolt. A railway worker photographed the smoke of the burning camp on 2 August 1943 (course).

6 million Jews murdered: two thirds of the Jews of Europe

The genocide of the Jews, the Shoah, killed 6 million people, two thirds of the Jews of Europe: gassed in the killing centres, shot dead by the Einsatzgruppen and their helpers, or killed by the work and living conditions of the ghettos and camps. The course map shows huge differences between countries: the communities of Poland and the Baltic states, under direct German occupation, were almost wiped out, while a larger share survived in some other countries. The genocide carried out the first driving force of the New European Order announced in the introduction: Europe as a "racial entity", purified by murder.

> **EXAMPLE** Course map "The genocide of the Jews of Europe": Poland 3,000,000 killed out of 3,350,000 (90%), Lithuania 97%, the Netherlands 100,000 out of 140,000 (71%), France 75,000 out of 270,000 (28%), Italy 8,000 out of 50,000 (16%).

How do we know? Survivors, perpetrators, plans

Our knowledge of the killing centres rests on several kinds of sources, each with its value and its limits: the testimonies of survivors (Avraham Lindwasser at the Eichmann trial in 1961, Avraham Bomba in Claude Lanzmann's film Shoah (1985) and in an interview of 1990), the documents and statements of the perpetrators (Stroop's report; the sketch plan of Treblinka drawn by Franz Stangl, its commandant, after his arrest in 1967 (he was tried in 1970)), and the plans drawn by survivors. Samuel Willenberg, a member of the camouflage commando, had access to most of the camp: he drew a plan of Treblinka to scale with every detail, considered one of the most reliable — except for the extermination area, which he never saw.

> **EXAMPLE** The Willenberg map as a DBQ exercise: largely useful (drawn to scale by an eyewitness; the outer shape of the camp almost matches the actual site), but limited for the extermination area, which was not known to him (course).

Key figures

Philippe Pétain
Marshal, head of the Vichy regime, which chose collaboration

Charles de Gaulle
General who refused the armistice and led Free France from London

Winston Churchill
British prime minister from 10 May 1940, who kept Britain fighting alone

Erwin Rommel
Commander of the 7th Panzer Division in the 1940 Blitzkrieg

Robert Frank
Historian who dates the "world war" 1937–1947 (with Alya Aglan, 2015)

Alfred Jodl
Chief of the Operations Staff of the German Armed Forces: June 1940 memorandum on Britain, May 1941 order against Soviet commissars

Paul Reynaud
French head of government until June 1940; de Gaulle served in his government

Joseph Stalin
Soviet leader: the speech of 6 November 1941 and Order No. 227 ("Not one step back!", 28 July 1942)

Walther von Reichenau
German field marshal, author of the Severity Order of 10 October 1941

Friedrich Paulus
Commander of the German army at Stalingrad; surrendered on 31 January 1943 (the battle ended on 2 February)

Heinrich Himmler
Head of the SS, to whom Stroop reported the end of the Warsaw ghetto (16 May 1943)

Jürgen Stroop
SS commander who crushed the Warsaw ghetto uprising (19 April–16 May 1943)

Raul Hilberg
Historian, The Destruction of the European Jews (1961): conversion, expulsion, destruction

Claude Lanzmann
Director of Shoah (1985), built on testimonies, including Hilberg's and Bomba's

Franz Stangl
Commandant of Treblinka; drew a sketch plan of the camp after his arrest (1967; tried in 1970)

Samuel Willenberg
Treblinka survivor (camouflage commando) who drew the most reliable plan of the camp

Avraham Bomba
Barber deported from Czestochowa to Treblinka (Sept. 1942); escaped in Jan. 1943; testified in 1990

Numbers

~60 million
Dead in the Second World War

105
French divisions in 1940 — none left in 1942

338,000
Allied soldiers evacuated from Dunkirk

1,850,000
French soldiers taken prisoner in 1940

20 million
Reichsmarks a day paid by France in occupation fees

~80,000
Jews deported from France; about 3% survived

43,000
Civilian dead of the Blitz in London, according to the course (usually the figure for the whole UK)

5 million
Deaths in the 200 days of Operation Barbarossa — a thousand an hour

2.8 million
Soviet prisoners of war killed, June 1941 – Feb. 1942, mainly by starvation

≈ 6 in 10
Soviet prisoners of war who died in German captivity: 3.3 of 5.7 million (outside the course)

1.13 million
Soviet casualties at Stalingrad (500,000 killed); 760,000 for Germany and its allies

≈ 91,000
German soldiers taken prisoner at Stalingrad (Worksheet 3: 95,000)

27–28 million
Soviet losses in the war: one in seven of the pre-war population

3/5
Share of all the dead of WWII who died on the Eastern Front

1,143,500 / 1,011,500
Soviet and German soldiers facing each other at Stalingrad, Nov. 1942

9.5 million
Jews in Europe around 1933, 6.76 million of them in Eastern Europe

440,000 / 4 km²
Jews locked up in the Warsaw ghetto; 146,000 inhabitants per km² in 1941

1 for 45
Births for deaths in the Warsaw ghetto in 1942

6
Killing centres in occupied Poland, operating from December 1941

3,000 an hour
Capacity of the Treblinka gas chambers from October 1942

876,000
People killed at Treblinka, including 874,000 Jews and 2,000 Roma

6 million
Jews murdered in the genocide: two thirds of the Jews of Europe

Vocabulary

THE WAR AND ITS AIMS

New European Order
Nazi rule over the continent, presented as saving European civilisation (key term).

Grossraum
“Great space”: the Nazi vision of Europe as a single economic unit serving Germany.

Einsatzgruppen
SS mobile killing units that shot civilians behind the Eastern Front.

Blitzkrieg
“Lightning war”: a rapid offensive combining tanks and aircraft.

phoney war
Sept. 1939–May 1940: war declared but almost no fighting in the west.

Maginot Line
French fortifications along the German border, not covering the Belgian one.

Operation Dynamo
Evacuation of 338,000 Allied soldiers from Dunkirk, 26 May–4 June 1940.

OCCUPIED FRANCE

armistice
Agreement ending the fighting, signed by France on 22 June 1940 at Rethondes.

demarcation line
The line separating the occupied zone from the “free zone” until November 1942.

Vichy regime
Marshal Pétain's authoritarian French state, based in Vichy, which chose collaboration.

collaboration
The policy of cooperating with the occupier, sought by Vichy from the armistice onwards.

government in exile
De Gaulle's French authority set up in London after the armistice.

STO
Forced sending of French workers to Germany, created by Vichy in 1942.

Aryanisation
Confiscation of Jewish businesses and property, handed to non-Jewish administrators.

exodus
The flight of some 8 million civilians southwards in May–June 1940.

black market
Illegal trade in rationed goods, fed by German requisitions.

BRITAIN ALONE (1940–41)

Blitz
The German bombing campaign against British cities in 1940–41.

Luftwaffe
The German air force.

RAF (Royal Air Force)
The British air force, whose survival prevented a German invasion.

air superiority
Control of the air over a battlefield, the condition for an invasion of Britain.

peripheral strategy
Jodl's option (June 1940): striking Britain in the Mediterranean and on its trade routes rather than directly.

Appeal of 18 June
De Gaulle's broadcast from London calling on the French to continue the fight (1940).

Pearl Harbor
American naval base in Hawaii bombed by Japan on 7 December 1941.

THE WAR IN THE EAST

Operation Barbarossa
The German invasion of the USSR, launched on 22 June 1941.

Germanisation
The Nazi plan to settle Germans in the East and enslave or expel the Slavs.

Übermensch / Untermensch
The Nazi racial hierarchy: the Aryan “superior man” against the Slavic “inferior man”.

Jewish Bolshevism
Nazi propaganda label merging communists and Jews into a single enemy.

political commissar
Communist party official attached to Red Army units; to be shot on capture (Jodl, May 1941).

scorched earth
Destroying crops, cattle and buildings so that the invader finds nothing.

war of annihilation (Vernichtungskrieg)
A war aiming at the total destruction of the enemy, without rules.

prisoner of war (POW)
A soldier captured by the enemy; Soviet POWs were starved to death in German hands.

Order No. 227
Stalin's order of 28 July 1942: “Not one step back!”

total war
The mobilisation of all of a society's resources and the blurring of front and rear.

turning point
The moment when the course of a war changes: Stalingrad, 1942–43.

Great Purges
Stalin's wave of arrests and executions of 1936–38, which also struck the officer corps of the Red Army.

Axis allies
States that fought alongside Germany against the USSR: Finland, Romania, Hungary, Slovakia, Italy, Croatia.

THE GENOCIDE

ghetto
Closed district of a city where the Nazis locked up the Jews (Warsaw: 440,000 in 4 km²).

genocide
The deliberate destruction of a people as such; the genocide of the Jews killed 6 million people.

Shoah
Hebrew word (“catastrophe”) for the genocide of the Jews; also the title of Lanzmann's film (1985).

Final Solution
Nazi euphemism for the murder of all the Jews of Europe.

Shoah by bullets
The mass shootings of Jews in the occupied USSR by the Einsatzgruppen and their helpers.

killing centre
Camp built to kill on arrival: Chelmno, Belzec, Sobibor, Treblinka, Majdanek, Auschwitz.

Sonderkommando
Small group of Jewish slaves forced to dispose of the bodies in a killing centre.

Zyklon B
The gas used in the gas chambers of Auschwitz and Majdanek.

selection
At Auschwitz and Majdanek, sorting on arrival between slave workers and those sent to the gas.